even to create new life-forms, either by writing genetic code or by inventing an inorganic code animating inorganic entities.

Even at the present moment, in the embryonic stage of the AI revolution, computers already make decisions about us – whether to give us a mortgage, to hire us for a job, to send us to prison. This trend will only increase and accelerate, making it more difficult to understand our own lives. Can we trust computer algorithms to make wise decisions and create a better world? That's a much bigger gamble than trusting an enchanted broom to fetch water. And it is more than just human lives we are gambling on. AI could alter the course not just of our species' history but of the evolution of all life-forms.

WEAPONISING INFORMATION

In 2016, I published *Homo Deus*, a book that highlighted some of the dangers posed to humanity by the new information technologies. That book argued that the real hero of history has always been information, rather than *Homo sapiens*, and that scientists increasingly understand not just history but also biology, politics and economics in terms of information flows. Animals, states and markets are all information networks, absorbing data from the environment, making decisions and releasing data back. The book warned that while we hope better information technology will give us health, happiness and power, it may actually take power away from us and destroy both our physical and our mental health. *Homo Deus* hypothesised that if humans aren't careful, we might dissolve within the torrent of information like a clump of earth within a gushing river, and that in the grand scheme of things humanity will turn out to have been just a ripple within the cosmic dataflow.

In the years since *Homo Deus* was published, the pace of change has only accelerated, and power has indeed been shifting from humans to algorithms. Many of the scenarios that sounded like science fiction in 2016 – such as algorithms that can create art, masquerade as human beings, make crucial life decisions about us and know more about us than we know about ourselves – are everyday realities in 2024.

Many other things have changed since 2016. The ecological crisis has intensified, international tensions have escalated, and a populist wave has